be in a recruitable position. Today, industry grudges the fact that the graduates who come out of colleges take nearly a year on the job to get trained. That is not the investment any industry wants to make. We need our graduates to come out ready for jobs. And many of them who go abroad for jobs should have the necessary skill set along with the language of the country they go to. So we'll be placing a lot of emphasis on that. Also looking at artificial intelligence, getting people to become savvy in using tools that can be derived out of artificial intelligence, sunrise sectors—investments to be coming in for rare earths, utilisation of green ammonia, making sure that India continues to have that lead in the services sector, other than making sure manufacturing happens in India as in the defence sector.

Q. What are the key areas where further reforms or big changes are likely?

Technology-driven changes are going to be top priority. Of course, start-ups in the area of fintech, technology for solutions for rural livelihood, the mission lifestyle for environment. You need equipment, technology that can make our lives simpler and sustainable. We are also looking at India's capabilities in the field of generic drugs. Reforms can no longer be itemised, they have to be continuous and systematic. Systemic reforms, which have been waiting for some time, will have to be undertaken and taken down to the panchayat and local body level. Permission for setting up a unit in a panchayat, for instance. You think the panchayats are doing it simpler? You need to get them to do it a lot more transparently and simply.

Q. Will GST also see some changes, including rationalisation?

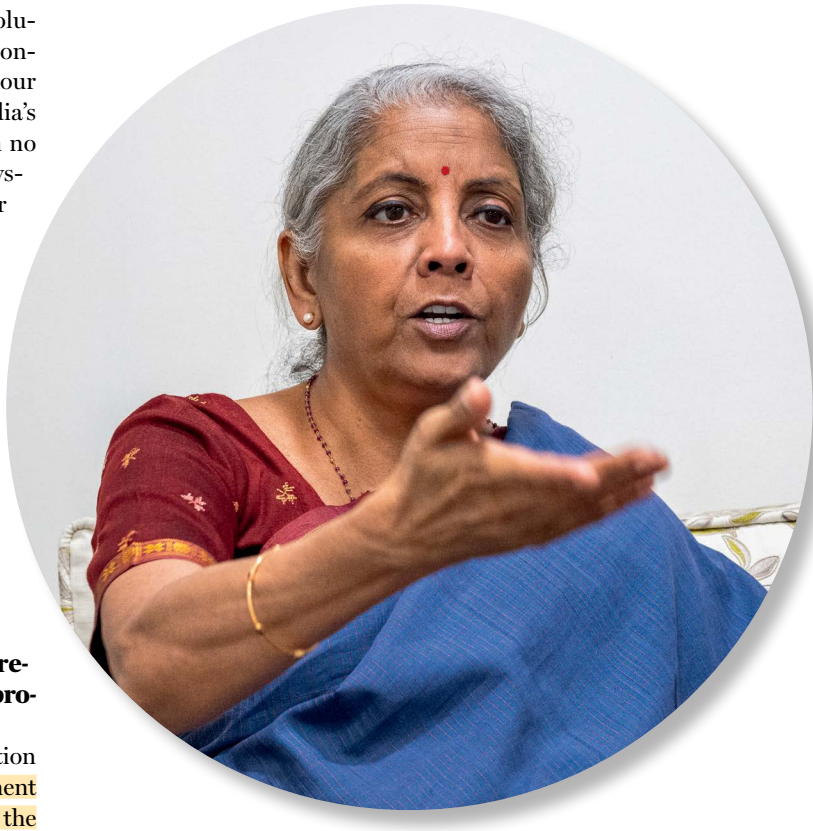
It's not an area ignored. There is a group of ministers and their report will have to be taken up to the next level after the post-election meeting by the GST Council.

Q. There are still many rough edges around Centre-State relations on GST and its sharing. How do you propose to address that?

I think this is a completely political game that the Opposition parties are playing. I challenge anyone to tell me if payment has been denied to a state, which is its due. I can, from the ministry of finance, tell you that, if anything, payments as per the recommendation of the Finance Commission have been done in time, sometimes well ahead of time. What I have to pay in January, I paid in December. What I have to pay in December, I have paid in November itself. But if you have a further issue to take up because of your performance or because of your population, or because of efficiencies that you brought in, you must talk to the next Finance Commission. It has already been constituted.

Q. This is what Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin has said at election rallies, that of the one rupee his state contributes to the central exchequer, it gets back only 29 paise as its share of taxes.

What kind of an argument is this, sensationalising and creating rift between people? What if within Tamil Nadu, Coimbatore and its neighbourhood, who contribute substantially to the state's revenue, say, "No, give it all back to us." The district from where the chief minister comes—Thanjavur—will not get money. Or Sriperumbudur. Is this how they want the country to be covered? Are ports and international airport terminals not being constructed in Tamil Nadu? Are Vande Bharat trains not going to Tamil Nadu? Who pays for all this? For a product manufactured in Tamil Nadu, the buyers are from all over India. So the money you get as tax is not your own. It's contributed by all countrymen. How convoluted are these arguments?



"Manufacturing will have to grow. What model it will take is a different story. Some would say 'Copy China'. Some would say don't. India will have to be *aatmanirbhar*"